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**FOR THOSE OF** us who love buying fresh vegetables from the neighbourhood store daily, the Covid-19-induced lockdowns were a stressful time. Using WhatsApp as a notepad to make lists of things one needed to buy—which many people were prone to do—one had to first send the list to the grocer on the messaging app and hope that he checked it before the fresh produce was sold out; next, one had to wait for the grocer to get back with the bill and then make the payment via an e-wallet or UPI. Sometimes, one would even have to call the grocer

to confirm that the payment was made, and then wait for the delivery to happen. The stress then led to many daily shoppers, like a relative based in Kolkata, to make—horror of horrors—weekly purchases.

After the lockdowns were lifted, the daily shoppers were back at their favourite neighbourhood grocery stores. My relative, a retired corporate executive, too, went back to his old routine, but a service he started using recently is causing some disruption in his habits. The service in question is JioMart on WhatsApp, which helps him order groceries and provisions in an interactive and seamless manner. And the convenience has convinced him to give his daily morning trips to the local grocer a miss.

But grocery is just one way you can use the messaging app. According to Ravi Garg, Director of Business Messaging-India, at Meta, you can also buy tickets for the Bengaluru metro on WhatsApp, and scan the e-ticket to board the train; and even book an Uber cab! These types of transactions on messaging apps are called conversational commerce, a term believed to have been coined by Chris Messina, the inventor of the hashtag, in 2015.

What exactly is conversational commerce? According to experts, conversational commerce is shopping on a messaging platform, where a chatbot engages in a conversation with a customer and helps her to buy a product, which is usually a small-ticket item. According

**86**

**PER CENT**

**SHARE OF INDIANS SPENDING TIME ONLINE WHO MESSAGE A BUSINESS AT LEAST ONCE A WEEK**

**83**

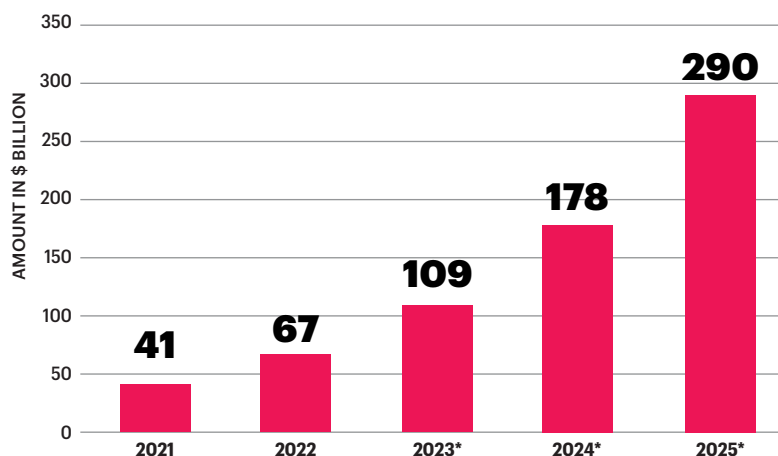
**PER CENT**

**SHARE OF INDIANS SPENDING TIME ONLINE WHO AGREE THAT MESSAGING IS A QUICK AND EASY WAY TO CONNECT WITH A BUSINESS**

**SOURCE:** 'BUSINESS MESSAGING USAGE RESEARCH' BY KANTAR (COMMISSIONED BY META)

## THE FUTURE OF SHOPPING

Spends on conversational commerce channels worldwide are expected to spike in the next few years



**SOURCE:** STATISTA; \*PROJECTIONS

TOTAL EXPECTED SPENDING OVER CONVERSATIONAL COMMERCE CHANNELS GLOBALLY